

STRESS BUSTER A Zumba session on April 30, at a school in Thiruvananthapuram

PRD KERALA

KERALA

'MOLLY' GOES ZUMBA

Rising substance abuse among teenagers had Kerala fretting. Pinarayi's replacement fix: dance!

By **Jeemon Jacob**

Takeaways

- **From June, Zumba will be the daily last class for Kerala's school students and teachers**
- **With surveys showing high teen drug use, the Pinarayi govt aims to 'reduce stress'**

DRUG ABUSE AMONG KERALA'S young, especially schoolchildren, has been making panicky headlines of late. The Marxist regime has now struck upon a novel Latin American fix. Novel and Latin American? Marquez? No, that was the teenaged Malayali of the 1980s. Their Gen Alpha legatees will also go Colombian, but with dance: Zumba, to be precise.

Beginning June, the next academic year, Kerala's schools will have the last period every day devoted to Zumba. The pilot run, in Thiruvananthapuram on April 30, saw 1,500 school students kick and stomp with gusto. At its launch, Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan counselled "students and teachers to participate actively" in the Zumba sessions to stay fit and reduce stress. Education minister V.. Sivankutty credits the 79-year-old CM with the idea of integrating Zumba into the curriculum. "It will make learning more enjoyable," he told INDIA TODAY. Zumba would "reduce stress", killing a causative link in drug abuse, he said.

Kerala has 1.16 million students enrolled in 4,693 government schools, 2.15 million in 7,216 aided schools and 389,000 students in 1,042 private ones—up to Class 10. Another 800,000 are enrolled in higher secondary and vocational schools.

A 2022 official survey of 600 under-19 teens had painted a troubling picture: 62.66 per cent were undergoing counselling and treatment; 25.83 per cent were accused in narcotics cases; 11.5 per cent (69) ticked both boxes. Some 97 per cent of teens had used some kind of drug at least once—82 per cent used cannabis, 7.5 per cent psychiatric drugs, 6.5 per cent LSD and 2.1 per cent MDMA. The Pinarayi regime aims to replace that with a simpler form of fun. ■

By **Ashish Misra**

THE SMELL OF SYRUP IN THE AIR, the hot *petha* rolling out of factories on both sides of the road, their candied memories travelling up and down the country in tiny coloured boxes by road, rail and now air—this is the identity of Agra's Noori Gate area. About seven kilometres from the Taj Mahal, these desi pâtisseries also churn out tiny, delicate monuments to the sweetness of composite culture. If the Taj was born in Shah Jahan's mind, legend has it that the *petha* was born in his royal kitchen—upon a royal firman to create a sweet delicacy as pure and white as the Taj! Marble was traded for white pumpkin, Agra's magic spell was spoken, and voila...the world was suddenly sweeter.

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That magic spell is being broken. The Noori Gate *petha* manufactories, running unbroken since the Mughal period, have been ordered to shift out of the city. That also breaks other ties with history. In 1929, the revolutionary Bhagat Singh, after shooting down British police officer John Saunders (the Lahore Conspiracy Case that led to his hanging), spent a few days hiding in a two-storey house right here in Noori Gate area.

Girish Singhal, 63, lives next to this house, beginning his *petha*-making career in his two-room abode in 1980. Over 40 years on, he's worried. "I do not have the resources to go 30 km away and set up business afresh. If there's too much pressure, I'll stop making *petha* and open a grocery shop but not move."

Anoop Mittal, 50, another Noori Gate native, conjures